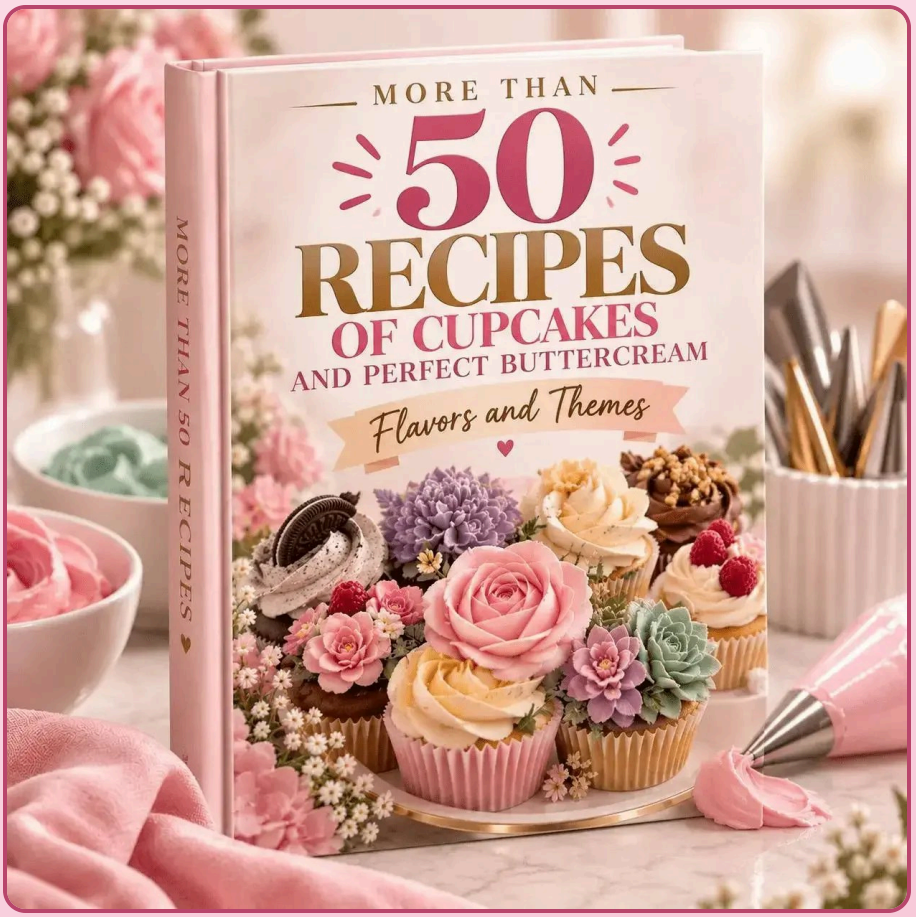
RESOURCE 1

Professional Recipes

56 cupcake, filling and buttercream recipes



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> *Welcome to Professional Recipes: 30 cupcakes and 26 buttercreams and fillings, written with exact US measurements so you can bake the same results every time.*

How to use these recipes

Every recipe lists the yield, a real timeline, ingredients in cups, tbsp, tsp and oz, numbered steps and a short note on storage, allergens and variations. Read the whole recipe once before you start, then set out every ingredient. Having everything measured and ready is the quickest way to avoid mistakes.

Pair a cupcake with a buttercream using the best-with line. A tender cupcake wants a lighter frosting; a sturdy one can carry a stiff piping buttercream for flowers. Cupcakes are grouped by family, and buttercreams by method, so you can compare textures and pick the right one for the design you plan to pipe.

US measurement equivalents

MEASURE	EQUALS
3 tsp	1 tbsp
4 tbsp	1/4 cup
8 tbsp	1/2 cup, or 1 stick of butter
16 tbsp	1 cup
1 cup	8 fluid oz
2 cups	1 pint
2 sticks butter	1 cup, or 8 oz
1 large egg white	about 2 tbsp
1 large egg yolk	about 1 tbsp

Spoon flour into the cup and level it with a knife. Scooping straight from the bag packs in extra flour and makes dry cupcakes. Sift powdered sugar before measuring for smooth frosting.

Oven temperatures

Most cupcakes here bake at **350°F** for 18 to 22 minutes. Every oven runs differently, so use an oven thermometer and check at the minimum time. A toothpick should come out with a few moist crumbs, and the tops should spring back lightly.

USE	TEMPERATURE
Standard cupcakes	350°F
Dense or fudgy batters	350°F, 20 to 22 minutes

USE	TEMPERATURE
Meringue base (Swiss)	Heat to 160°F
Italian and French syrup	Cook to 240°F
Butter for buttercream	About 65°F to 68°F, cool but pliable

Butter temperature

For cake batters use softened butter at about 68°F. For buttercream, butter that is cool and pliable gives the best structure for piped flowers. Warm, shiny butter makes soft, greasy frosting.

Mixing tips

- Bring eggs, milk and buttermilk to room temperature for a smooth, even batter.
- Cream butter and sugar until pale and fluffy, about 3 minutes, scraping the bowl twice.
- Add dry and wet ingredients in parts and stop as soon as no flour streaks remain.
- Fill liners two-thirds full with a scoop so every cupcake bakes the same.
- Cool completely before frosting, or the buttercream will slide and melt.

Fixing buttercream

Soupy meringue buttercream usually needs to be chilled 10 minutes and rewhipped. Curdled looking? Keep whipping; it comes back together. Too soft for flowers: chill the bowl and beat in a little more powdered sugar.

Allergens and substitutions

Most recipes contain **dairy, egg and gluten**, and some contain tree nuts. Always label what is inside, and ask guests about allergies before you serve. Check every ingredient label, as products change. Dairy-free and egg-free versions are included, but they are not a guarantee of safety for anyone with a medical condition.

Food safety

Cook egg whites for Swiss meringue to 160°F, and use hot syrup at 240°F for Italian and French buttercreams. Do not leave decorated cupcakes at room temperature for more than 2 hours, and follow food-safety guidelines at events, especially in warm weather or with cream cheese and filled cupcakes.

Storage

- Unfrosted cupcakes: airtight at room temperature up to 2 days, or frozen up to 2 months.
- American and Russian-style buttercream: up to 2 weeks chilled; bring to room temperature and rewhip.
- Meringue buttercreams: 3 days cool, up to 1 week chilled, freeze for 1 month.

- Cream cheese frosting and filled cupcakes: refrigerate and serve within 3 days.

BEFORE YOU BAKE

☐ Preheat the oven and check it with a thermometer

☐ Bring dairy and eggs to room temperature

☐ Measure with level cups and spoons

☐ Line the pan and prepare the buttercream tools

☐ Plan food-safe storage for your finished cupcakes

Next step

Choose one cupcake and one buttercream from this list, bake a test batch, and note any changes in the margin. Results vary with your oven, ingredients and technique.

Cupcake recipes (30)

Classic Vanilla Bean Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs, room temperature
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 tsp vanilla bean paste
- 1/2 cup whole milk, room temperature

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder and salt in a bowl.
3. Beat the butter and sugar 3 minutes on medium until pale and fluffy.
4. Add the eggs one at a time, then the vanilla extract and bean paste.
5. Add the dry mix in three parts, alternating with the milk, and mix just until smooth.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: American buttercream or Swiss meringue buttercream

Notes: Keeps 2 days covered at room temperature. Contains dairy, egg, gluten. Swap 1 tsp almond extract for half the vanilla.

Deep Chocolate Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 cup all-purpose flour
- 1/2 cup unsweetened cocoa powder
- 3/4 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup vegetable oil
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 1 large egg plus 1 egg yolk
- 1/2 cup buttermilk
- 1/2 cup hot coffee or hot water
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, cocoa, baking soda, baking powder and salt.
3. Whisk the oil, sugar, egg, yolk, buttermilk and vanilla until smooth.
4. Stir the dry mix into the wet, then stir in the hot coffee; the batter will be thin.
5. Fill liners halfway and bake 18 to 20 minutes.
6. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Chocolate or vanilla buttercream

Notes: Keeps 3 days. Contains egg, dairy, gluten. Hot water works if you avoid coffee; the cocoa flavor stays rich.

Golden Butter Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 3/4 cups cake flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 3/4 cup (1 1/2 sticks) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 cup granulated sugar
- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 3/4 cup whole milk

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Sift the cake flour, baking powder and salt together.
3. Cream the butter and sugar 4 minutes until light.
4. Beat in the eggs one at a time, then the vanilla.
5. Alternate the flour mix and milk in three additions, mixing on low.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Any piped flower buttercream

Notes: Sturdy crumb for tall piped swirls. Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten.

Chocolate Fudge Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 20-22 min, cool 30 min

- 3/4 cup all-purpose flour
- 1/2 cup unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, melted
- 1 cup brown sugar, packed
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 cup sour cream
- 1/4 cup whole milk
- 2 oz semisweet chocolate, melted and cooled

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, cocoa, baking powder and salt.
3. Whisk the melted butter and brown sugar, then the eggs, vanilla, sour cream and milk.
4. Stir in the cooled chocolate, then fold in the dry mix until just combined.
5. Fill liners two-thirds full and bake 20 to 22 minutes.
6. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Swiss meringue or cream cheese buttercream

Notes: Dense and fudgy; keeps 3 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten. Check chocolate labels for nut traces.

Vanilla Buttermilk Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp baking soda
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 cup buttermilk, room temperature

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda and salt.
3. Cream the butter and sugar 3 minutes.
4. Add the eggs and vanilla, beating well after each.
5. Add the dry mix and buttermilk alternately, ending with flour.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Light American buttercream

Notes: Light tangy crumb. Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten. Use milk plus 1 tsp lemon juice if no buttermilk.

Marble Vanilla-Chocolate Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 25 min, bake 20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 cup whole milk
- 2 tbsp unsweetened cocoa powder
- 2 tbsp hot milk

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Make a vanilla batter: cream butter and sugar, add eggs and vanilla, then alternate flour mix and milk.
3. Move one third of the batter to a small bowl.
4. Whisk the cocoa with the hot milk into a paste and fold into that portion.
5. Spoon vanilla and chocolate batter into liners and swirl once with a toothpick.
6. Bake 20 minutes.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Vanilla or chocolate buttercream

Notes: Swirl only once to keep clean ribbons. Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten.

Chocolate Chip Vanilla Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 cup whole milk
- 1/2 cup mini chocolate chips tossed in 1 tsp flour

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder and salt.
3. Cream the butter and sugar 3 minutes, then add eggs and vanilla.
4. Alternate the dry mix and milk, mixing gently.
5. Fold in the floured mini chips.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Vanilla or chocolate buttercream

Notes: Mini chips stay suspended better than large ones. Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten; chocolate may contain nut traces.

Lavender Honey Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1 tbsp culinary dried lavender buds, finely ground
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 2/3 cup granulated sugar
- 3 tbsp honey
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 cup whole milk

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Grind the lavender with 2 tbsp of the sugar so no large buds remain.
3. Whisk the flour, baking powder and salt.
4. Cream the butter, lavender sugar, rest of the sugar and honey 3 minutes.
5. Add eggs and vanilla, then alternate the dry mix with the milk.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Honey vanilla or lavender buttercream

Notes: Use culinary lavender only; more than 1 tbsp tastes soapy. Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten. Honey is not for infants.

Lemon Raspberry Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tbsp lemon zest
- 2 tbsp lemon juice
- 1/2 cup whole milk
- 3/4 cup fresh raspberries, tossed in 1 tsp flour

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Rub the zest into the sugar until fragrant.
3. Cream the butter and lemon sugar 3 minutes, then add the eggs.
4. Alternate the flour mix with the milk and lemon juice.
5. Fold in 1/2 cup of the raspberries gently.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs. Top each with a raspberry before baking.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Raspberry or lemon buttercream

Notes: Frozen raspberries work; do not thaw. Keeps 2 days chilled. Contains dairy, egg, gluten.

Rose Vanilla Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 tsp rose water
- 1/2 cup whole milk

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder and salt.
3. Cream the butter and sugar 3 minutes.
4. Beat in the eggs, vanilla and rose water.
5. Alternate the dry mix and milk, mixing just until smooth.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Rose buttercream piped as roses

Notes: Rose water is strong; measure exactly. Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten.

Matcha Green Tea Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1 1/2 tbsp ceremonial-grade matcha powder, sifted
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 cup whole milk

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Sift the flour, baking powder, salt and matcha twice for an even color.
3. Cream the butter and sugar 3 minutes.
4. Add the eggs and vanilla.
5. Alternate the dry mix and milk.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: White chocolate or vanilla buttercream

Notes: Matcha browns slightly when baked. Keeps 2 days. Contains caffeine, dairy, egg, gluten.

Strawberry Cream Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/3 cup whole milk
- 1/2 cup freeze-dried strawberries, crushed to powder

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, salt and strawberry powder.
3. Cream the butter and sugar 3 minutes.
4. Add the eggs and vanilla.
5. Alternate the dry mix and milk.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Strawberry or vanilla buttercream

Notes: Freeze-dried fruit gives flavor without extra moisture. Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten.

Pistachio Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 25 min, bake 20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 cup all-purpose flour
- 1/2 cup finely ground shelled pistachios
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 1/2 tsp almond extract
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 cup whole milk

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Pulse the pistachios with 1 tbsp of the flour until fine, not oily.
3. Whisk with the remaining flour, baking powder and salt.
4. Cream the butter and sugar 3 minutes, then add eggs and extracts.
5. Alternate the dry mix and milk.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Vanilla or pistachio buttercream

Notes: Contains tree nuts (pistachio); label clearly. Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten. Nut-free: use 1/2 cup extra flour, skip nuts.

Orange Blossom Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tbsp orange zest
- 1/2 tsp orange blossom water
- 1/2 cup whole milk

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Rub the zest into the sugar.
3. Cream the butter and orange sugar 3 minutes.
4. Add eggs and orange blossom water.
5. Alternate the flour mix and milk.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Vanilla or honey buttercream

Notes: Orange blossom water is potent; stay at 1/2 tsp. Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten.

Chai Spice Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/2 tsp ground ginger
- 1/4 tsp ground cardamom
- 1/8 tsp ground cloves
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup brown sugar, packed
- 2 large eggs
- 1/2 cup strong brewed chai, cooled

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, salt and spices.
3. Cream the butter and brown sugar 3 minutes.
4. Add the eggs one at a time.
5. Alternate the dry mix and chai.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Brown sugar or cinnamon buttercream

Notes: Chai contains caffeine; use decaf tea if preferred. Keeps 3 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten.

Pumpkin Spice Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 20-22 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp baking soda
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 2 tsp pumpkin pie spice
- 1/2 cup vegetable oil
- 3/4 cup brown sugar, packed
- 2 large eggs
- 3/4 cup pumpkin puree (not pie filling)
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda, salt and spice.
3. Whisk the oil and sugar, then the eggs, pumpkin and vanilla.
4. Fold in the dry mix until just combined.
5. Fill liners two-thirds full and bake 20 to 22 minutes.
6. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Cream cheese buttercream

Notes: Keeps 3 days chilled. Contains egg, gluten. Dairy-free as written; frost with a dairy-free buttercream.

Gingerbread Molasses Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 tbsp ground ginger
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/4 tsp ground cloves
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 1/2 cup brown sugar, packed
- 1/3 cup molasses
- 1 large egg
- 3/4 cup hot water

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking soda, salt and spices.
3. Cream the butter and sugar, then beat in the molasses and egg.
4. Add the dry mix in two parts, alternating with the hot water.
5. Fill liners two-thirds full and bake 20 minutes.
6. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Cream cheese or vanilla buttercream

Notes: Batter is thin by design. Keeps 4 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten.

Apple Cinnamon Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup brown sugar, packed
- 2 large eggs
- 1/2 cup unsweetened applesauce
- 1/3 cup finely diced peeled apple

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, cinnamon and salt.
3. Cream the butter and sugar 3 minutes, then add the eggs.
4. Mix in the applesauce, then the dry mix.
5. Fold in the diced apple.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Caramel or cinnamon buttercream

Notes: Keeps 3 days chilled. Contains dairy, egg, gluten. Swap pear for apple for a softer flavor.

Carrot Spice Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 25 min, bake 22 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 2/3 cup vegetable oil
- 3/4 cup brown sugar, packed
- 2 large eggs
- 1 1/2 cups finely grated carrot
- 1/3 cup crushed pineapple, well drained

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda, cinnamon and salt.
3. Whisk the oil, sugar and eggs until smooth.
4. Stir in the carrot and pineapple.
5. Fold in the dry mix until just combined.
6. Bake 22 minutes.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Cream cheese buttercream

Notes: Keeps 3 days chilled. Contains egg, gluten. Dairy-free as written. Add 1/3 cup chopped walnuts only if no nut allergy.

Cranberry Orange Holiday Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tbsp orange zest
- 1/2 cup orange juice
- 3/4 cup fresh or frozen cranberries, chopped

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder and salt.
3. Cream the butter, sugar and zest 3 minutes, then add eggs.
4. Alternate the dry mix and juice.
5. Fold in the cranberries.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: White chocolate or vanilla buttercream

Notes: Keeps 2 days chilled. Contains dairy, egg, gluten. Dust chopped cranberries with flour to avoid sinking.

Dairy-Free Vanilla Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup neutral oil
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 cup unsweetened oat or soy milk, room temperature

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder and salt.
3. Whisk the oil, sugar, eggs and vanilla until smooth.
4. Stir in the dry mix and plant milk alternately.
5. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
6. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Dairy-free buttercream

Notes: Keeps 3 days. Contains egg, gluten; dairy-free. Check plant milk labels for soy or nut allergens.

Egg-Free Vanilla Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp baking soda
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, melted
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 3/4 cup buttermilk
- 1 tbsp white vinegar
- 2 tsp vanilla extract

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda and salt.
3. Whisk the butter, sugar, buttermilk, vinegar and vanilla.
4. Fold the wet into the dry until just combined; do not overmix.
5. Fill liners two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes.
6. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: American or Swiss meringue buttercream

Notes: Crumb is tender; keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, gluten; egg-free. Handle gently when peeling liners.

Vegan Chocolate Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1/3 cup unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1 cup granulated sugar
- 1/3 cup neutral oil
- 1 cup water
- 1 tbsp white vinegar
- 2 tsp vanilla extract

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, cocoa, baking soda, salt and sugar.
3. Add the oil, water, vinegar and vanilla.
4. Whisk until smooth; the batter is thin.
5. Fill liners halfway and bake 18 to 20 minutes.
6. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Dairy-free chocolate buttercream

Notes: Free of dairy and egg; contains gluten. Keeps 3 days. Check cocoa and sugar labels if strictly vegan.

Dairy-Free Lemon Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup neutral oil
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tbsp lemon zest
- 1/4 cup lemon juice
- 1/4 cup unsweetened oat milk

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Rub the zest into the sugar.
3. Whisk the oil, lemon sugar and eggs.
4. Stir in the juice and oat milk.
5. Fold in the flour, baking powder and salt.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Dairy-free vanilla buttercream

Notes: Keeps 3 days. Contains egg, gluten; dairy-free. Swap oat milk for soy if needed.

Egg-Free Chocolate Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/4 cups all-purpose flour
- 1/3 cup unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 1/3 cup vegetable oil
- 1 cup buttermilk
- 1 tbsp white vinegar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, cocoa, baking soda, salt and sugar.
3. Whisk the oil, buttermilk, vinegar and vanilla.
4. Combine until just smooth.
5. Fill liners two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes.
6. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Chocolate or cream cheese buttercream

Notes: Keeps 3 days. Contains dairy, gluten; egg-free. Use plant milk plus 1 tbsp vinegar for dairy-free.

Funfetti Birthday Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 cup whole milk
- 1/3 cup rainbow jimmies sprinkles

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder and salt.
3. Cream the butter and sugar 3 minutes, then add eggs and vanilla.
4. Alternate the dry mix and milk.
5. Fold in the jimmies sprinkles by hand.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Vanilla buttercream with rainbow swirl

Notes: Use jimmies, not nonpareils, which bleed. Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten.

Red Velvet Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/4 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 tbsp unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1/2 tsp baking soda
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup vegetable oil
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 1 large egg
- 1/2 cup buttermilk
- 1 tbsp red gel food coloring
- 1 tsp white vinegar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, cocoa, baking soda and salt.
3. Whisk the oil, sugar and egg, then the buttermilk, coloring, vinegar and vanilla.
4. Fold the dry mix into the wet until just combined.
5. Fill liners two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes.
6. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Cream cheese buttercream

Notes: Keeps 3 days chilled. Contains dairy, egg, gluten. Gel coloring keeps the batter from thinning.

Wedding White Almond Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 25 min, bake 20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups cake flour
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 4 large egg whites, room temperature
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 tsp almond extract
- 1/2 cup whole milk

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Sift the cake flour, baking powder and salt.
3. Cream the butter and sugar 4 minutes.
4. Beat in the egg whites in two additions, then the extracts.
5. Alternate the dry mix and milk.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Ivory Swiss meringue buttercream

Notes: Pure white crumb for events. Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten. Almond extract is flavoring, not whole nuts.

Sparkling Celebration Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 cup sparkling white grape juice, flat and room temperature

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder and salt.
3. Cream the butter and sugar 3 minutes.
4. Add eggs and vanilla.
5. Alternate the dry mix and grape juice.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Vanilla or pink Swiss meringue buttercream

Notes: Alcohol-free and family friendly. Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten.

Coconut Cream Cupcakes

makes 12 cupcakes · Prep 20 min, bake 18-20 min, cool 30 min

- 1 1/2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tsp coconut extract
- 1/2 cup canned coconut milk, stirred
- 1/3 cup sweetened shredded coconut

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F and line a 12-cup muffin pan with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder and salt.
3. Cream the butter and sugar 3 minutes, then add eggs and coconut extract.
4. Alternate the dry mix and coconut milk.
5. Fold in the shredded coconut.
6. Fill each liner two-thirds full and bake 18 to 20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
7. Cool in the pan 5 minutes, then move to a wire rack and cool completely before frosting.

Best with: Vanilla or lime buttercream

Notes: Keeps 2 days. Contains dairy, egg, gluten; coconut is treated as a tree nut on some labels. Check with guests.

Fillings (3)

Lemon Curd Filling

makes about 1 1/2 cups, fills 12 cupcakes · Prep 15 min, cook 10 min, chill 2 hours

- 3 large egg yolks
- 1/2 cup granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup lemon juice
- 1 tbsp lemon zest
- 1/4 cup (1/2 stick) unsalted butter, cubed
- pinch of salt

1. Whisk the yolks, sugar, juice and zest in a saucepan.
2. Cook on low, stirring, to 170°F until thick.
3. Remove from heat; whisk in the butter and salt.
4. Strain through a sieve.
5. Press plastic wrap on the surface and chill 2 hours.

Best with: Vanilla, raspberry, lavender cupcakes

Notes: Keeps 1 week chilled. Contains egg, dairy. Cooked to 170°F.

Raspberry Compote Filling

makes about 1 cup, fills 12 cupcakes · Prep 5 min, cook 10 min

- 2 cups fresh or frozen raspberries
- 1/3 cup granulated sugar
- 1 tbsp lemon juice
- 1 tbsp cornstarch
- 2 tbsp water

1. Simmer the raspberries, sugar and lemon juice 5 minutes.
2. Mix the cornstarch with the water.
3. Stir it in and boil 1 minute until thick.
4. Strain out the seeds if you prefer.
5. Cool fully before filling.

Best with: Lemon, vanilla, chocolate cupcakes

Notes: Keeps 1 week chilled. Free of dairy and egg. Pipe a thick buttercream dam around the filling.

Salted Caramel Filling

makes about 1 cup, fills 12 cupcakes · Prep 5 min, cook 12 min

- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 3 tbsp water
- 1/2 cup heavy cream, warmed
- 3 tbsp unsalted butter
- 1/2 tsp flaky sea salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

1. Cook the sugar and water over medium heat, undisturbed, until deep amber.
2. Carefully whisk in the warm cream; it will bubble.
3. Whisk in the butter, salt and vanilla.
4. Cool to room temperature.

Best with: Chocolate, apple, gingerbread cupcakes

Notes: Hot sugar can burn; take care. Keeps 2 weeks chilled. Contains dairy.

Buttercreams (23)

Classic American Buttercream

makes about 4 cups, enough for 12 piped cupcakes · Prep 15 min

- 1 cup (2 sticks) unsalted butter, softened
- 4 cups powdered sugar, sifted
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 3 to 4 tbsp heavy cream

1. Beat the butter 5 minutes until pale.
2. Add the powdered sugar one cup at a time on low.
3. Add the vanilla and salt.
4. Add cream 1 tbsp at a time until smooth and pipeable.
5. Whip 2 minutes on medium.

Best with: Vanilla, chocolate or fruit cupcakes

Notes: Keeps 3 days at cool room temperature, 2 weeks chilled. Contains dairy. Rewhip after chilling.

Crusting Buttercream

makes about 4 cups, enough for 12 piped cupcakes · Prep 15 min

- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 1/2 cup solid vegetable shortening
- 4 cups powdered sugar, sifted
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 2 to 3 tbsp whole milk

1. Beat the butter and shortening 4 minutes.
2. Add the powdered sugar gradually on low.
3. Add vanilla and salt.
4. Add milk 1 tbsp at a time until spreadable.
5. Let the finished piping set 15 to 20 minutes to form a light crust.

Best with: Smooth finishes, transport, bouquets

Notes: Crusts for smoothing and easy handling. Keeps 2 weeks chilled. Contains dairy. Follow food-safety guidelines on warm days.

Stiff Buttercream for Piped Flowers

makes about 3 cups, enough for 12 flower cupcakes · Prep 15 min, chill 10 min

- 3/4 cup (1 1/2 sticks) unsalted butter, cool but pliable
- 1/4 cup solid vegetable shortening
- 4 cups powdered sugar, sifted
- 1 tsp clear vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1 to 2 tbsp whole milk

1. Beat the butter and shortening just 2 minutes; do not whip in extra air.
2. Add the powdered sugar on low until a thick paste forms.
3. Add vanilla, salt and only 1 tbsp milk.
4. Test: a petal should hold a sharp edge. Add milk by the teaspoon only if it cracks.
5. Chill 10 minutes if it feels warm, then knead briefly before piping.

Best with: Piped roses, peonies, ranunculus, daisies

Notes: Cool kitchen is key. Keeps 2 weeks chilled. Contains dairy. Add gel coloring a little at a time.

Chocolate American Buttercream

makes about 4 cups, enough for 12 piped cupcakes · Prep 15 min

- 1 cup (2 sticks) unsalted butter, softened
- 3 1/2 cups powdered sugar, sifted
- 3/4 cup unsweetened cocoa powder, sifted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/4 cup heavy cream

1. Beat the butter 4 minutes.
2. Add sugar and cocoa in two parts on low.
3. Add vanilla and salt.
4. Stream in the cream until smooth.
5. Whip 2 minutes.

Best with: Vanilla and chocolate cupcakes

Notes: Keeps 3 days cool, 2 weeks chilled. Contains dairy. Dutch-process cocoa gives deeper color.

Classic Swiss Meringue Buttercream

makes about 5 cups, enough for 12 to 15 piped cupcakes · Prep 20 min, cook 8 min, whip 15 min

- 4 large egg whites
- 1 cup granulated sugar
- 1 1/2 cups (3 sticks) unsalted butter, cubed, cool but pliable
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt

1. Whisk the egg whites and sugar in a heatproof bowl over simmering water.
2. Heat, whisking, to 160°F so the egg is cooked and the sugar dissolves; check with a thermometer.
3. Whip on high until stiff, glossy and the bowl feels cool, about 8 minutes.
4. Add butter a few cubes at a time on medium.
5. If it looks curdled, keep whipping; add vanilla and salt.

Best with: Wedding and elegant piping

Notes: Cooked to 160°F for food safety. Keeps 3 days cool, 1 week chilled. Contains egg, dairy. Rewhip after chilling.

Lemon Swiss Meringue Buttercream

makes about 5 cups · Prep 20 min, cook 8 min, whip 15 min

- 4 large egg whites
- 1 cup granulated sugar
- 1 1/2 cups (3 sticks) unsalted butter, cubed
- 3 tbsp lemon juice
- 1 tbsp lemon zest
- 1/4 tsp salt

1. Heat egg whites and sugar over simmering water, whisking, to 160°F.
2. Whip to stiff, glossy peaks until cool.
3. Add the butter gradually.
4. Beat in the salt and zest.
5. Add lemon juice a tablespoon at a time; keep whipping until smooth.

Best with: Raspberry, blueberry, vanilla cupcakes

Notes: Cooked to 160°F. Keeps 3 days cool. Contains egg, dairy. Do not add juice too fast or it may split.

Chocolate Swiss Meringue Buttercream

makes about 5 cups · Prep 25 min, cook 8 min, whip 15 min

- 4 large egg whites
- 1 cup granulated sugar
- 1 1/2 cups (3 sticks) unsalted butter, cubed
- 6 oz semisweet chocolate, melted and cooled
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt

1. Heat egg whites and sugar over simmering water to 160°F.
2. Whip to stiff, cooled peaks.
3. Add butter a few cubes at a time.
4. Beat in the cooled chocolate on low.
5. Add vanilla and salt, then whip until silky.

Best with: Chocolate or vanilla cupcakes

Notes: Chocolate must be cool, not hot. Keeps 3 days cool. Contains egg, dairy; check chocolate for nut traces.

Matcha Swiss Meringue Buttercream

makes about 5 cups · Prep 20 min, cook 8 min, whip 15 min

- 4 large egg whites
- 1 cup granulated sugar
- 1 1/2 cups (3 sticks) unsalted butter, cubed
- 1 1/2 tbsp ceremonial-grade matcha powder, sifted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt

1. Heat egg whites and sugar to 160°F.
2. Whip to stiff cooled peaks.
3. Add the butter gradually.
4. Whisk the matcha with 1 tbsp of buttercream to a paste.
5. Fold the paste back in with vanilla and salt, then whip.

Best with: Matcha, vanilla, pistachio cupcakes

Notes: Cooked to 160°F. Keeps 3 days cool. Contains egg, dairy, caffeine.

Classic Italian Meringue Buttercream

makes about 5 cups · Prep 25 min, whip 15 min

- 5 large egg whites
- 1 1/4 cups granulated sugar
- 1/3 cup water
- 1 3/4 cups (3 1/2 sticks) unsalted butter, cubed and cool
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt

1. Start whipping the egg whites to soft peaks as the syrup cooks.
2. Boil the sugar and water to 240°F without stirring.
3. Stream the hot syrup down the side of the bowl into the whipping whites; this cooks them well above 160°F.
4. Whip on high until the bowl is just warm, about 10 minutes.
5. Add the butter gradually, then the vanilla and salt.

Best with: Wedding and events

Notes: Hot syrup causes burns; pour carefully. Keeps 3 days cool. Contains egg, dairy. Very stable in warm rooms.

Vanilla Bean Italian Meringue Buttercream

makes about 5 cups · Prep 25 min, whip 15 min

- 5 large egg whites
- 1 1/4 cups granulated sugar
- 1/3 cup water
- 1 3/4 cups (3 1/2 sticks) unsalted butter, cubed
- 1 tbsp vanilla bean paste
- 1/4 tsp salt

1. Whip the egg whites to soft peaks.
2. Cook sugar and water to 240°F.
3. Stream the syrup into the whites; whip until cool.
4. Add the butter a few cubes at a time.
5. Beat in the vanilla bean paste and salt.

Best with: Strawberry, lemon, chocolate cupcakes

Notes: Keeps 3 days cool. Contains egg, dairy. Rewhip after chilling until smooth.

Rose Italian Meringue Buttercream

makes about 5 cups · Prep 25 min, whip 15 min

- 5 large egg whites
- 1 1/4 cups granulated sugar
- 1/3 cup water
- 1 3/4 cups (3 1/2 sticks) unsalted butter, cubed
- 1/2 tsp rose water
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt

1. Whip egg whites to soft peaks while cooking the syrup to 240°F.
2. Stream the syrup into the whites and whip until cool.
3. Add the butter gradually.
4. Add rose water, vanilla and salt.
5. Whip until smooth.

Best with: Rose vanilla, raspberry cupcakes

Notes: Rose water is strong; add by 1/4 tsp. Keeps 3 days cool. Contains egg, dairy.

Classic French Buttercream

makes about 3 1/2 cups · Prep 25 min, whip 12 min

- 6 large egg yolks
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 1/4 cup water
- 1 cup (2 sticks) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt

1. Whip the yolks until pale and thick.
2. Cook sugar and water to 240°F.
3. Stream the syrup into the yolks and whip until cool, about 8 minutes.
4. Add the butter gradually.
5. Add vanilla and salt.

Best with: Chocolate, coffee, caramel cupcakes

Notes: Rich and yellow; yolks are cooked by the hot syrup. Keeps 3 days cool. Contains egg, dairy.

Coffee French Buttercream

makes about 3 1/2 cups · Prep 25 min, whip 12 min

- 6 large egg yolks
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 1/4 cup water
- 1 cup (2 sticks) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 tbsp instant espresso powder dissolved in 1 tbsp hot water, cooled
- 1/4 tsp salt

1. Whip the yolks until pale.
2. Cook sugar and water to 240°F.
3. Stream into the yolks; whip until cool.
4. Add the butter gradually.
5. Add the cooled coffee and salt; whip smooth.

Best with: Chocolate and vanilla cupcakes

Notes: Contains caffeine. Keeps 3 days cool. Contains egg, dairy.

Salted Caramel French Buttercream

makes about 3 1/2 cups · Prep 30 min, whip 12 min

- 6 large egg yolks
- 3/4 cup granulated sugar
- 1/4 cup water
- 1 cup (2 sticks) unsalted butter, softened
- 1/4 cup thick caramel sauce, cooled
- 1/2 tsp flaky sea salt

1. Whip the yolks until pale.
2. Cook sugar and water to 240°F.
3. Stream into the yolks and whip until cool.
4. Add the butter gradually.
5. Fold in the caramel and salt.

Best with: Apple, gingerbread, chocolate cupcakes

Notes: Keeps 3 days cool. Contains egg, dairy. Use cooled caramel so the butter does not melt.

Russian-Style Stiff Buttercream (Vanilla)

makes about 3 cups · Prep 20 min

- 1 cup (2 sticks) unsalted butter, cool but pliable
- 1/2 cup sweetened condensed milk, at room temperature
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup powdered sugar, sifted

1. Beat the butter 5 minutes until very pale.
2. Add the condensed milk 1 tbsp at a time, beating fully between additions.
3. Add vanilla and salt.
4. Beat in the powdered sugar for body.
5. Chill 10 minutes if soft.

Best with: Russian piping tip flowers

Notes: Stiff enough for dense Russian-tip flowers. Keeps 1 week chilled. Contains dairy. Add the milk slowly to avoid splitting.

Russian-Style Chocolate Buttercream

makes about 3 cups · Prep 20 min

- 1 cup (2 sticks) unsalted butter, cool but pliable
- 1/2 cup sweetened condensed milk
- 1/4 cup unsweetened cocoa powder, sifted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup powdered sugar

1. Beat the butter 5 minutes.
2. Add the condensed milk gradually.
3. Beat in the cocoa, vanilla and salt.
4. Add the powdered sugar.
5. Rest 5 minutes before piping.

Best with: Chocolate or vanilla cupcakes

Notes: Keeps 1 week chilled. Contains dairy. Dark coloring needs less gel.

Russian-Style Cream Cheese Stiff Buttercream

makes about 3 cups · Prep 20 min, chill 15 min

- 3/4 cup (1 1/2 sticks) unsalted butter, cool
- 4 oz full-fat block cream cheese, cold
- 1/2 cup sweetened condensed milk
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup powdered sugar

1. Beat the butter 4 minutes.
2. Add the cold cream cheese in small pieces.
3. Add the condensed milk slowly.
4. Add vanilla, salt and sugar.
5. Chill 15 minutes before piping.

Best with: Carrot and red velvet cupcakes

Notes: Refrigerate finished cupcakes; serve within 3 days. Contains dairy. Follow food-safety guidelines at events.

Classic Cream Cheese Frosting

makes about 4 cups, enough for 12 piped cupcakes · Prep 15 min, chill 20 min

- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 8 oz full-fat block cream cheese, cool
- 3 1/2 cups powdered sugar, sifted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt

1. Beat the butter 2 minutes.
2. Add the cream cheese and beat just until smooth.
3. Add the sugar on low in two parts.
4. Add vanilla and salt.
5. Chill 20 minutes before piping.

Best with: Carrot, pumpkin, red velvet cupcakes

Notes: Softer than buttercream. Keep refrigerated; serve within 3 days. Contains dairy.

Stabilized Cream Cheese Buttercream

makes about 4 cups · Prep 20 min, chill 20 min

- 3/4 cup (1 1/2 sticks) unsalted butter, softened
- 6 oz full-fat block cream cheese, cold
- 4 cups powdered sugar, sifted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1 tbsp cornstarch

1. Beat the butter 4 minutes.
2. Add cold cream cheese in pieces.
3. Whisk the cornstarch into 1 cup of the sugar and add with the rest.
4. Add vanilla and salt.
5. Chill 20 minutes; it pipes soft swirls.

Best with: Spiced cupcakes

Notes: Pipes simple petals only. Refrigerate; serve within 3 days. Contains dairy.

Lemon Cream Cheese Frosting

makes about 4 cups, enough for 12 piped cupcakes · Prep 15 min, chill 20 min

- 1/2 cup (1 stick) unsalted butter, softened
- 8 oz full-fat block cream cheese
- 3 1/2 cups powdered sugar, sifted
- 1 tbsp lemon zest
- 1 tbsp lemon juice
- 1/4 tsp salt

1. Beat the butter 2 minutes.
2. Add cream cheese until smooth.
3. Add the sugar on low.
4. Add zest, juice and salt.
5. Chill 20 minutes.

Best with: Blueberry, vanilla, lemon cupcakes

Notes: Refrigerate; serve within 3 days. Contains dairy. Juice thins it, so add slowly.

Dairy-Free Vanilla Buttercream

makes about 4 cups, enough for 12 piped cupcakes · Prep 15 min

- 1 cup (2 sticks) dairy-free baking sticks, softened
- 4 cups powdered sugar, sifted
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 3 to 4 tbsp unsweetened plant milk

1. Beat the dairy-free sticks 4 minutes.
2. Add the sugar gradually on low.
3. Add vanilla and salt.
4. Add plant milk 1 tbsp at a time.
5. Whip 2 minutes.

Best with: Dairy-free vanilla cupcakes

Notes: Use sticks, not tub spread. Keeps 1 week chilled. Dairy-free; check labels for soy.

Dairy-Free Chocolate Buttercream

makes about 4 cups, enough for 12 piped cupcakes · Prep 15 min

- 1 cup (2 sticks) dairy-free baking sticks, softened
- 3 1/2 cups powdered sugar, sifted
- 3/4 cup unsweetened cocoa powder, sifted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/4 cup unsweetened oat milk

1. Beat the sticks 4 minutes.
2. Add sugar and cocoa in two parts.
3. Add vanilla and salt.
4. Add oat milk gradually.
5. Whip until smooth.

Best with: Vegan chocolate cupcakes

Notes: Keeps 1 week chilled. Dairy-free; contains oat. Check cocoa labels.

Coconut Cream Dairy-Free Buttercream

makes about 3 1/2 cups · Prep 15 min, chill overnight

- 1 can (13.5 oz) full-fat coconut cream, chilled overnight
- 1/2 cup dairy-free baking sticks, softened
- 3 cups powdered sugar, sifted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt

1. Scoop only the solid cream from the chilled can.
2. Beat the sticks 3 minutes.
3. Add the sugar gradually.
4. Fold in the cream, vanilla and salt.
5. Chill 15 minutes before piping.

Best with: Tropical and vanilla cupcakes

Notes: Soft; use for swirls. Keep chilled, 4 days. Dairy-free; coconut is treated as a tree nut on some labels.

Next step

Bake one recipe from each group this week, pair it with a buttercream, and pipe a simple flower on top.